worth. While having tea, we watched the Jhelum river as it hit the rapids.

'Fly the pennant and uncover the star plate,' I ordered. This was something I never did normally. Why I took this decision on this day, I cannot explain.

'Today, I will lead the convoy through the town upto the Division HQ', I said to myself as I drove off with a zip, with the other three vehicles following behind.

'Sir, did you notice the looks of the young man at the tea stall where we had stopped for tea,' remarked Suresh, looking earnestly at me.

'Yes, indeed. I felt he appeared nervous and fidgety, I wonder why!'

'I think he was a terrorist,' said Suresh.

Soon our convoy entered the town. The highway passed right through the middle – as in a typical Kashmiri town. There were rows of houses and shops on both sides. It seemed a normal summer morning. Children were on the way to school, and the shopkeepers and wayside fruit and vegetable vendors were laying out their wares. Horse-driven carts, the primary mode of conveyance in a town like this, were moving to and fro. Just like any other day.

We had barely gone beyond Tashkent Chowk, the main crossroads in the centre of Baramulla, when all hell broke loose! Hot and lethal metal spewed by machine guns and rifles rained down on my convoy from houses and rooftops, and loud explosions of grenades and rockets enveloped the area in a cloud of dust. There was bedlam and one could notice people running helter-skelter for cover. Some just dived to the ground to get out of the line of fire, and shielded their heads. Fortunately, there were no fatalities, but some were wounded or had a close shave and were under shock.

A surge of adrenaline pumped into my bloodstream automatically, as bullets and shrapnel whizzed past. It felt that the next burst would hit us. The shock effect lasted a few seconds.

Regaining my composure, I yelled into my radio, 'Hullo all stations Zulu, keep moving, I repeat, keep moving – and don't stop